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FREE MINI GUIDE

YELLOWSTONE & ZION: WHEN TO GO

WHEN TO GO. WHEN TO SKIP. WHAT TO BOOK. WHERE TO PARK.

Two of the most popular parks, done properly. Best months, crowds, permits, trailhead parking, and the one mistake everybody makes. Print it, save it, take it with you.



YELLOWSTONE

ZION

PARKS_HQ EDITION · 2026

Facts checked against nps.gov on Oct 2, 2026. Rules change. Check nps.gov before you go.

WELCOME. READ THIS FIRST.

HOW THIS GUIDE WORKS

National park trips go wrong in the same boring ways. People arrive at 11 am, can't park, get hot, get mad, and blame the mountain. This mini guide fixes that for two big ones. It tells you when to go, when to skip, what to book ahead, and where to leave the car.

BEST MONTHS AT A GLANCE

PARK	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
YELLOWSTONE	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
ZION	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D

■ Best months ■ Fine ■ Month to avoid (crowds, heat, weather) □ Closures or limited access

IF YOU HATE CROWDS

- Yellowstone: May or October (check road dates).
- Zion: late fall or winter.

IF YOU WANT PEAK SCENERY

- Yellowstone: May for baby bison and elk calves, late Sept into Oct for the elk rut.
- Zion: late Oct into early Nov, when fall color reaches the canyon floor.

EVERY PARK GETS TWO PAGES

Page one: best months, months to avoid, crowd level, the one must-do, the thing tourists get wrong, booking and permit notes, and a short packing list.

Page two: an official NPS trail map, top trails with distances, trailhead parking, standout view stops, and the in-park highlights worth the detour.

QUICK RULES THAT APPLY EVERYWHERE

- Stay 100 yards from bears and wolves and 25 yards from other wildlife. Bison and elk count.
- Stay on trails and boardwalks.
- Store food properly in bear country. Carry bear spray where NPS recommends it.
- Don't count on cell service. Download offline maps.
- Arrive early. NPS says it again and again for a reason.

THE HONEST FINE PRINT

Every number in here comes from nps.gov or an official NPS map, checked on **Oct 2, 2026**. If I couldn't confirm something, I say "check nps.gov" instead of guessing. The month and crowd ratings are my editorial read of what NPS says. They are not official.

RULES CHANGE

Fees, permits, shuttle dates and road closures change every season. Check each park's alerts page the day you leave.

Geysers, bison, and a very fragile sense of personal space.

5

ENTRANCES

6,000 FT+

MOST OF PARK AT

NONE NEEDED

RESERVATIONS



BEST MONTHS

May for baby bison and elk calves and thin crowds. Late September into October for the elk rut, roadside bears, and fewer mosquitos. Check which roads are open first.

MONTHS TO AVOID

July and August (busiest stretch is June-September, plus afternoon thunderstorms, wildfire haze and mosquitos). Most roads close to regular cars from early November to late April.

CROWD LEVEL

Very high June-Sept. Moderate May and Oct. Lightest Mar, Apr, Nov (when most roads are closed).

MUST-DO

Grand Prismatic Spring from the overlook trail. The boardwalk view is a steamy blur. The hill gets you the rainbow.

WHAT TOURISTS GET WRONG

Thinking it's one park you can "knock out" in a day. Five entrances, and driving between them takes hours. Also: bison are not fluffy cows. They are landlords, and you are behind on rent. Stay 25 yards back (100 yards from bears and wolves).

BOOKING, PERMITS & TIMING

- No vehicle reservations. You do need an entrance pass.
- 2026 regular-vehicle road dates: most roads open Apr 17, May 1 or May 8 through Oct 31. Dunraven Pass and the Beartooth Highway ran May 22-Oct 12.
- Only the North Entrance to Northeast Entrance road stays open all year to regular vehicles.
- Bridge work in 2026: single-lane delays of up to 15 min at Gardner River High Bridge and Bridge Bay, up to 30 min at Yellowstone River Bridge. Dates change, so check nps.gov.
- NPS tip: be at an entrance before 7 am or after 12 pm, and skip main attractions 10 am-4 pm.

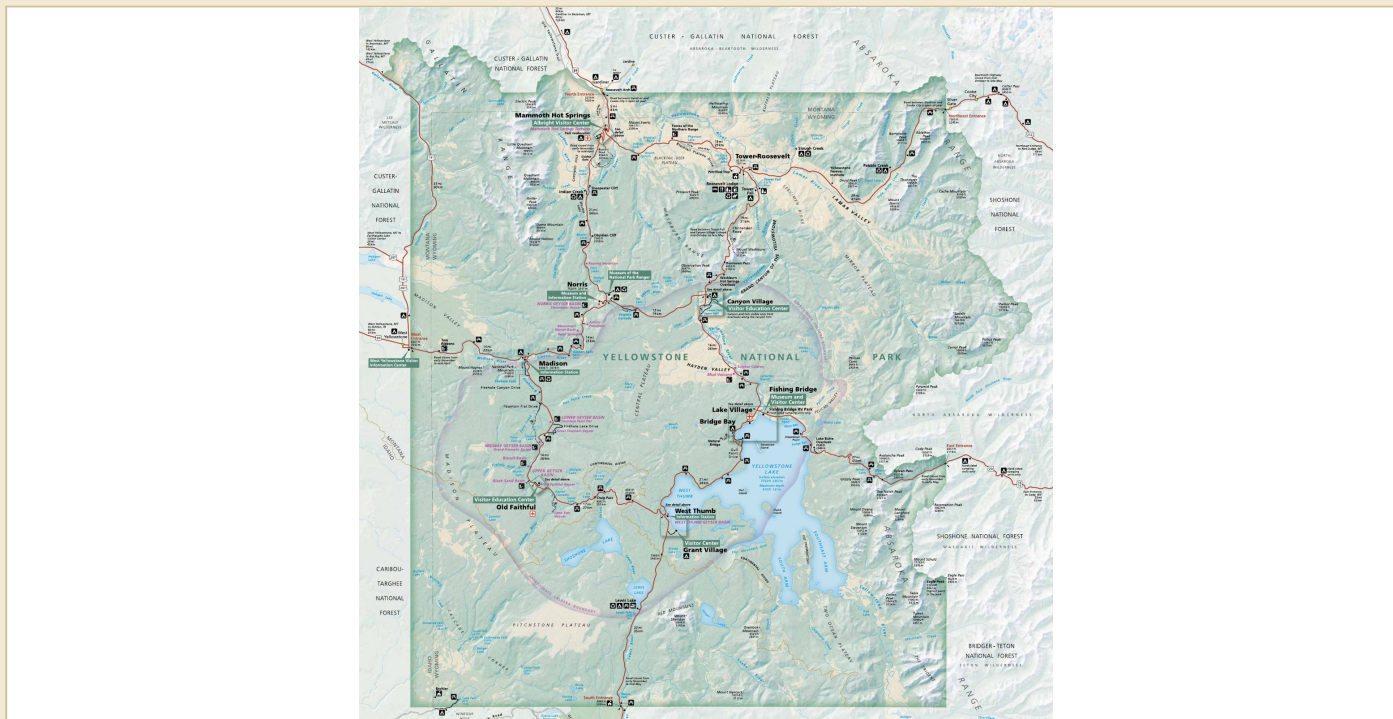
SHORT PACKING LIST

- Bear spray (and know how to use it)
- Layers: rain or snow can show up any month
- Binoculars for wildlife (so you can stay far away)
- Sun hat and sunscreen at 6,000+ ft
- Snacks, because services are far apart
- Offline map: cell service is spotty

Know before you go (as of Oct 2, 2026). Soaking in hot springs is prohibited and more than 20 people have died from burns. Stay on boardwalks. The geysers do not care about your itinerary.

HIDDEN GEM · LONE STAR GEYSER

A quiet 4.8-mile round-trip walk beside the Firehole River, south of Old Faithful. It erupts about every 3 hours (30-45 ft), but intervals vary. Source: NPS.



Map: National Park Service (official NPS map, cropped). Not to scale. Get the current version at nps.gov/yell.

TOP TRAILS

Grand Prismatic Overlook	1.2 mi round trip, 105 ft gain over 0.6 mi
Brink of the Lower Falls	0.7 mi round trip, drops 600 ft over 0.4 mi (so you climb it on the way back)
Mount Washburn from Dunraven Pass	6 mi round trip. Trailhead is 4.5 mi north of Canyon Junction. NPS: grizzlies frequent it in fall, hike in groups of 3+, and it is not recommended in Sept and Oct.

TRAILHEAD PARKING

- Grand Prismatic Overlook trailhead is the Fairy Falls lot, 1 mile south of Midway Geyser Basin. NPS says parking is "very limited."
- An NPS monitoring report (2018, so dated) found that lot filling around 10-11 am. Plan on being there early or late.
- Old Faithful's lot is so big and busy that NPS's 2018 survey couldn't count it. Eat lunch somewhere else.

VIEW STOPS ON THE DRIVE IN

North entrance: Golden Gate & Rustic Falls. Road squeezes through Golden Gate canyon on the way up from Mammoth, then opens onto Swan Lake Flat.

West entrance: Gibbon Falls. Roadside waterfall you can see from the pullout. Easy first stop after West Yellowstone.

South entrance: West Thumb. Pull up to Yellowstone Lake (over 7,000 ft high) before you hit the geyser basins.

Northeast: Lamar Valley. Wide open valley and the park's famous wildlife-watching stretch. Bring binoculars.

YOU HAVE TO SEE THIS

Steamboat Geyser, Norris. The world's tallest active geyser. Major eruptions shoot water over 300 ft, but nobody can predict them. If it blows, mineral spray can wreck your car's paint, so don't park beside it.

Brink of the Lower Falls. Stand at the top of a 308-ft waterfall. It feels like cheating.

Petrified Tree & Specimen Ridge. A stone tree you can drive to. Specimen Ridge has the largest concentration of petrified trees in the world.

Old Faithful. One of nearly 500 geysers and one of only six rangers currently predict. Eruption times are posted at the Visitor Education Center.

Red cliffs, a river you walk in, and a shuttle schedule you actually need to read.

FREE, MANDATORY IN SEASON

SHUTTLE

CLOSED TO CARS

CANYON DRIVE

NONE (BOTTOM UP)

NARROWS PERMIT

J Jan	F Feb	M Mar	A Apr	M May	J Jun	J Jul	A Aug	S Sep	O Oct	N Nov	D Dec
Best	Fine	Avoid	Limited or closed	Fine	Avoid	Avoid	Avoid	Fine	Best	Best	Best

BEST MONTHS

April, and late October into early November when fall color reaches the canyon floor. March and April days warm up, but nights are cold and the Narrows may be closed from snowmelt.

MONTHS TO AVOID

June through August: regularly over 100°F, monsoon July-September, and parking often full by 9 am. Memorial Day, July 4 and Labor Day weekends are the busiest.

CROWD LEVEL

High to very high most of the year. December and January are calmer except holidays.

MUST-DO

Walk the Riverside Walk to the start of the Narrows. If the water and forecast are good, wade in.

WHAT TOURISTS GET WRONG

Trying to drive up the canyon (private cars can't use Scenic Drive in shuttle season), and missing the last shuttle (NPS says you may have to walk up to 9 miles). Also thinking all of Angels Landing needs a permit. The permit starts at Scout Lookout. The trail to Scout Lookout doesn't need one.

BOOKING, PERMITS & TIMING

- Shuttle is free, no ticket or reservation. Zion Canyon Line 2026: May 17-Sep 12 7 am-7 pm. Sep 13-Oct 24 last shuttle from the Visitor Center 6:00 pm. Oct 25-Nov 28 last from VC 5:00 pm. No service Nov 29-Dec 25.
- Angels Landing (Scout Lookout to the summit) needs a permit year-round. Day-before lottery runs 12:01 am-3 pm MT the day before. \$6 application fee (covers up to 6 people), plus \$3 per person if you win. The winter lottery (Dec 1-Feb 28, 2027) is open Oct 1-Oct 20.
- The Narrows bottom-up needs no permit. NPS closes it when the river runs over 150 cfs or a flash flood warning is out, so check the forecast and flow rate.
- Pets are not allowed on the shuttle.

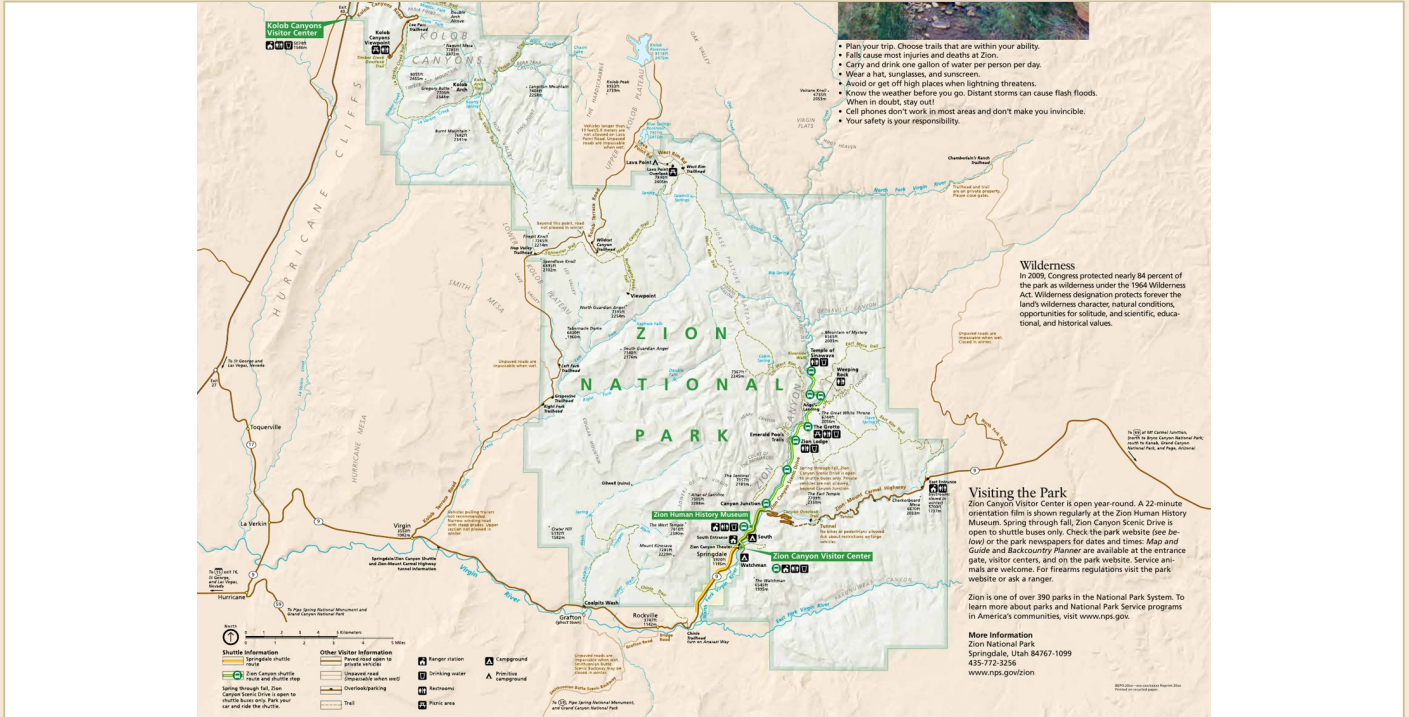
SHORT PACKING LIST

- Closed-toe shoes that can get wet
- Trekking pole if you'll wade the Narrows
- Water, lots (1 gallon per person per day is NPS's guidance)
- Sun hat and sunscreen
- Waterproof bag for your phone
- Layers for cold canyon mornings

Know before you go (as of Oct 2, 2026). Flash floods can come from storms 15-20 miles upstream (NPS monsoon release, Jul 29, 2026). When in doubt, stay out.

HIDDEN GEM · KOLOB CANYONS

A quieter section off I-15 Exit 40. Drive the 5-mile road to Timber Creek Overlook (about 1 mi round trip). Show your Zion pass at the Kolob visitor center. Source: NPS.



Map: National Park Service (official NPS map, cropped). Not to scale. Get the current version at [nps.gov/zion](https://www.nps.gov/zion).

TOP TRAILS

Riverside Walk	About 1 mi one way from Temple of Sinawava (shuttle stop 9), paved. 2.2 mi round trip per NPS.
The Narrows (bottom up)	9.4 mi out and back to Big Spring. All in-water. No bathrooms.
Angels Landing	5.4 mi round trip, 1,488 ft gain, about 4 hr. Permit from Scout Lookout (last half mile has a chain on a knife-edge ridge).
Lower Emerald Pools / Weeping Rock	Lower Emerald Pools 1.2 mi round trip from stop 5. Weeping Rock is a steep 0.4 mi paved trail from stop 7, but NPS lists it closed for rockfall, so check nps.gov .

TRAILHEAD PARKING

- Visitor Center lot has over 350 free spaces and often fills by early to mid-morning. The Human History Museum has 51.
- Springdale has paid parking plus a free town shuttle and a pedestrian entrance. Honestly the easiest move.
- It takes about 45 min on the shuttle from the Visitor Center to the Temple of Sinawava. Plan the last bus.

VIEW STOPS ON THE DRIVE IN

- East side: Zion-Mt. Carmel Highway.** A 25-mile road with a 1.1-mile tunnel and window galleries cut into the rock. Large vehicles need an escort or restrictions.
- Canyon Overlook.** 1.0 mi round trip just east of the tunnel. It is not a shuttle stop.
- Checkerboard Mesa.** The cross-hatched rock near the East Entrance. Pull over, look, move along.
- Canyon Junction & Court of the Patriarchs (stop 4).** Short, steep trail to an overlook of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, named in 1916.

YOU HAVE TO SEE THIS

- Weeping Rock.** An alcove that really does "weep." Water seeps through porous Navajo Sandstone. NPS lists the area closed for rockfall, so check [nps.gov](https://www.nps.gov) before you go.
- The Narrows.** The Virgin River is the trail, and the Navajo Sandstone layer is about 2,000 ft thick.
- Angels Landing chains.** The half-mile route with chains is famous, and you may spot a California condor nearby. Keep your distance.
- Lower Emerald Pools.** 1.2 mi round trip from the Zion Lodge stop (stop 5). A short walk to a waterfall and pools.

3-6 MONTHS OUT

- ☐ Pick your park and your month using the chart. Then check which roads and areas are open that month.
- ☐ Zion: check the Angels Landing permit lottery if you want the chains. Yellowstone: no vehicle reservation, but you do need an entrance pass.
- ☐ Look at lodging and campground reservations on Recreation.gov and the park's lodging page.

1-2 MONTHS OUT

- ☐ Buy or confirm your pass.
- ☐ Read the park's current conditions and alerts page. Closures change.
- ☐ Download offline maps and the NPS app content for your park.

1 WEEK OUT

- ☐ Check the weather forecast. In Zion, also check flash-flood potential and the flow rate before the Narrows.
- ☐ Pack by season. Check the packing list on your park's page.
- ☐ Plan your first-hour stops. Most parks fill by about 9-10 am.

TRIP DAY

- ☐ Be at the gate early. NPS often suggests before 7-8 am or after mid-afternoon.
- ☐ Park once and use shuttles where they exist (Zion's is the main way up the canyon).
- ☐ Fill water bottles, check trail status, tell someone your plan.
- ☐ Keep your distance from wildlife and leave no trace.

FREE TOOL: BOOKING-WINDOW REMINDERS

Lotteries and campsite windows open on a clock. Pick your park in our free calendar, download an .ics file into Apple, Google or Outlook Calendar, and get reminders 1 day and 15 minutes before each release (like the Zion Angels Landing lotteries). It doesn't book anything for you, and a few entries are still marked unverified, so confirm on Recreation.gov. exploreparks.github.io/explore-parks-calendar

THE TEN-SECOND PLAN

Pick the month. Check what's open. Book what needs booking. Get there early. Park once. Carry water. Respect the animals. That's the whole thing.



LIKED THE SAMPLE?
**TEN PARKS.
ONE GUIDE.**

Yellowstone and Zion are just two of them. The full guide covers ten parks with the same best months, crowd levels, permits, parking and trail maps. 28 pages, US Letter, print it or keep it on your phone.

YELLOWSTONE

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YOSEMITE

ZION

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